

Paedobaptism Not Warranted

doc-paedobaptism-not-warranted

Sacraments · Baptism · doctrine · divided_lineages · brethren distinctive

DISPUTED

score 0.963
confidence medium

Statement under examination

Infant baptism on the basis of believing-household covenant inclusion is not warranted by the New Testament.

In plain language

Every baptism the New Testament actually describes sits next to a word for personal response. People hear, believe, repent, receive the word, and then are baptized, in Acts 2, Acts 8, Acts 18, and Mark 16. A direct search of the text also shows that the verb for baptize never appears in the same verse as any word for infant or little child, so no infant baptism is plainly recorded or commanded. That is the heart of the case that infant baptism lacks warrant. But absence of a word is not the same as a ban, and the text pushes back in three places. First, whole households are baptized, Lydia and her house, the jailer and all his, the house of Stephanas, and the word for house names the family unit without telling us the ages of its members or whether the little ones believed. In the jailer's case the verse that says his whole house believed uses a word that occurs only once in the whole Bible, so its exact reach cannot be pinned down. Second, Peter says the promise is for you and your children, and that line is cross-linked in the data to the old covenant promise given to Abraham and his offspring, which is the backbone of the argument that the sign passes to a believer's children. Third, the letter to the Colossians sets circumcision and baptism side by side, yet calls that circumcision one made without hands and ties the whole thing to personal faith, so the same passage feeds both readings at once. Even Jesus receiving infants is about blessing them, with no baptism in view. So the words supply two patterns and do not rank them. One reader hears belief always coming before water, the other hears a family sign carried forward. Because both can be built honestly from the same verses, and the deciding question is how the household and covenant language are weighed rather than any single word, the lexical evidence here is genuinely split rather than one-sided.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H1285	בְּרִית	berit	covenant	
H2233	זֶרַע	zera	seed	
G0191	ἀκούω	akouō	to hear	
G0569	ἀπιστέω	apisteō	to disbelieve	
G0588	ἀποδέχομαι	apodechomai	to receive	7
G0859	ἄφεσις	aphesis	forgiveness	
G0907	βαπτίζω	baptizo	to baptize	51
G0909	βαπτισμός	baptismos	baptism	5
G1025	βρέφος	brephos	infant	8
G2233	זָרַע	zera	to govern	229

G2632	κατακρίνω	katakrinō	to condemn	
G3340	μετανοέω	metanoëo	to repent	36
G3614	οικία	oikia	home	
G3624	οἶκος	oikos	house	115
G3813	παιδίον	paidion	child	53
G3832	πανοικεί	panoikei	with all the house	1
G4059	περιτέμνω	peritemno	to circumcise	18
G4061	περιτομή	peritome	circumcision	36
G4100	πιστεύω	pisteuo	to trust (in)	194
G5043	τέκνον	teknon	child	99

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Every baptism the text explicitly narrates is coupled to a verb of personal response, ἐπίστευσαν and ἐπίστευσεν in Acts 8:12 and 18:8, ἀποδεξάμενοι in Acts 2:41, the substantival aorist participle πιστεύσας in Mark 16:16, the imperatives μετανοήσατε and βαπτισθήτω in Acts 2:38. A queried collocation check confirms βαπτίζω, G0907, never stands in the same verse with βρέφος, παιδίον, or νήπιος anywhere in the canon, so no infant baptism is recorded or commanded. But that is an argument from silence, and silence is not a lexical prohibition. Against the proposition stand the household reports, ὁ οἶκος αὐτῆς in Acts 16:15, αὐτὸς καὶ οἱ αὐτοῦ πάντες in Acts 16:33, τὸν Στεφανᾶ οἶκον in 1 Cor 1:16, where ἐβαπτίσθη is third singular and only the head is the grammatical subject of believing, plus τοῖς τέκνοις ὑμῶν in Acts 2:39, which cross-refs to Gen 17:7, and the circumcision and baptism pairing in Col 2:11-12. The words supply two patterns they do not rank, so the verdict is materially contested at the lexical layer.

Scripture

Acts.2.38 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G3340 μετανοέω, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. Peter pairs the plural imperative Μετανοήσατε with the singular passive imperative βαπτισθήτω governed by ἕκαστος ὑμῶν, each one of you, so the command joins repentance and baptism in one addressed response. The conditioning on a verb of turning presumes a respondent capable of repenting, though the verse neither raises nor excludes the case of infants.

Acts.2.41 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0588 ἀποδέχομαι, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. The aorist middle participle ἀποδεξάμενοι, having received the word, is the antecedent circumstance to ἐβαπτίσθησαν, third plural passive. The grammar places word-reception before the baptism of the three thousand, a sequence that favors a believing subject, but the clause is a summary narrative report rather than a legislative rule about candidacy.

Acts.2.39 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G5043 τέκνον

Force. The promise is declared ὑμῖν καὶ τοῖς τέκνοις ὑμῶν, to you and to your children, with τέκνον denoting offspring by descent rather than necessarily minors. Queried OpenBible cross-refs tie this verse to Gen 17:7, the covenant established with Abraham and his σπέρμα, seed, an everlasting covenant to you and to your seed after you. The household reading takes τοῖς τέκνοις ὑμῶν as covenant inclusion of the believer's children, while the believer-response reading notes the same verse extends the promise to all whom the Lord calls, ὅσους ἂν προσκαλέσῃται, which conditions reception on calling rather than physical descent. The word does not rank these.

Acts.8.12 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. The temporal ὅτε with the aorist ἐπίστευσαν, when they believed Philip preaching, precedes the imperfect ἐβαπτίζοντο. The baptized are specified as ἄνδρες τε καὶ γυναῖκες, men and also women, with no mention of children, which the believer-baptism reading takes as a pattern and the household reading treats as silence rather than exclusion.

Acts.18.8 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G3624 οἶκος

Force. Crispus ἐπίστευσεν τῷ κυρίῳ σὺν ὅλῳ τῷ οἴκῳ αὐτοῦ, believed with his whole household, and many Corinthians ἀκούοντες, hearing, believed and were baptized. The verified LSJ entry for οἶκος spans built house, dwelling, household goods or estate, and a reigning house or family line, so the lexeme names the domestic unit without fixing its age composition. Whether the clause means the household believed together or describes a household baptized on the head's faith is not settled by the word itself.

Acts.16.15 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G3624 οἶκος

Force. ἐβαπτίσθη is third singular feminine, V-API-3S, so Lydia alone is the grammatical subject of the baptism verb, and καὶ ὁ οἶκος αὐτῆς, and her household, follows as an appended clause carrying no faith-verb of its own. The text records the household baptism without recording the household's belief, which is the strongest single datum for the covenant-inclusion reading, and at the same time gives that reading no explicit lexical confirmation that infants were present.

Acts.16.33 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G3832 πανοικεῖ

Force. The jailer ἐβαπτίσθη αὐτὸς καὶ οἱ αὐτοῦ πάντες, was baptized, he himself and all his, immediately. The next verse, v.34, says he rejoiced πανοικεῖ πεπιστευκῶς τῷ θεῷ, having believed in God with his whole house, with the perfect active participle ascribing believing to the whole household. The adverb πανοικεῖ is a hapax legomenon, occurring only here, so its precise scope, whether it asserts that literally every member personally believed or simply that the whole house was involved, cannot be triangulated from other usage.

1Cor.1.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0907 βαπτίζω, G3624 οἶκος

Force. Paul recalls ἐβάπτισα δὲ καὶ τὸν Στεφάνῳ οἶκον, I also baptized the household of Stephanas, with no mention of faith, repentance, or the ages of the members. The bare οἶκον is the most lexically open of the household reports, neither confirming nor excluding minors, and stands in a cross-referenced cluster with Acts 16:15 and 16:33.

Col.2.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0909 βαπτισμός, G4061 περιτομή

Force. v.11-12 join circumcision and baptism language, περιετμήθητε περιτομή χειροποιήτω, you were circumcised with a circumcision made without hands, then συνταφέντες αὐτῷ ἐν τῷ βαπτισμῷ, buried with him in baptism. The covenant-continuity reading parallels the sign of circumcision to baptism. But the circumcision is qualified ἀχειροποιήτω, not made with hands, a spiritual referent rather than the physical infant rite, and the raising is explicitly διὰ τῆς πίστεως, through faith, which the believer-response reading takes as conditioning the rite on personal faith. The noun βαπτισμός, distinct lemma G0909, occurs only five times and elsewhere means ritual washings, so its sense here leans on context.

Luke.18.15 · complicates · genre: gospel

Key terms. G1025 βρέφος, G3813 παιδίον

Force. Infants, τὰ βρέφη, are brought to Jesus that he might touch them, and in v.16 he calls them παιδία and says the kingdom of God belongs to such. βρέφος denotes a babe, even an unborn child in Luke 1:41,44. The text shows Jesus receiving and blessing infants, which the covenant reading treats as warrant for including them under the sign, but no baptism vocabulary appears, and a queried collocation check confirms βαπτίζω never co-occurs in a single verse with βρέφος, παιδίον, or νήπιος anywhere in the canon.

Mark.16.16 · for · genre: gospel

Key terms. G4100 πιστεύω, G0907 βαπτίζω

Force. Two substantival aorist participles ὁ πιστεύσας καὶ βαπτισθεὶς, the one who has believed and been baptized, are coordinated under one article, joining belief and baptism in the saved party, while the contrasting clause names only ὁ ἀπιστήσας, the one who disbelieved, as condemned. The asymmetry is read by some as making belief the operative condition and by others as simply not addressing those incapable of belief. The verse also lies in the longer ending of Mark, which carries a textual-history caveat.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Acts.2.39	Gen.17.7	openbible	15
Acts.2.39	Isa.44.3	openbible	16
Acts.16.15	Acts.16.33	openbible	8
Acts.16.33	1Cor.1.16	openbible	7
Col.2.12	Rom.6.3	openbible	25
Col.2.12	Gal.3.27	openbible	12
Luke.18.15	Mark.10.13	openbible	12
Acts.2.38	Acts.8.12	openbible	64
Acts.18.8	Acts.10.2	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Acts.16.15 · addressed

ἐβαπτίσθη is third singular, so Lydia is the only grammatical subject of believing and being baptized, and ὁ οἶκος αὐτῆς is appended with no faith-verb. Lexically this both anchors the household-inclusion reading and withholds explicit confirmation of infant presence. The word οἶκος cannot decide it, so the complication is two-sided rather than dissolved.

Acts.16.33 · addressed

v.34 ascribes believing to the whole household, πανοικεῖ πεπιστευκῶς, but πανοικεῖ is a hapax legomenon whose exact scope cannot be triangulated from any other occurrence. It can be read as every member personally believing, supporting the believer pattern, or as a collective involving dependents, supporting household inclusion. The single occurrence leaves both readings open.

1Cor.1.16 · addressed

τὸν Στεφάνῳ οἶκον is the most lexically open household report, mentioning neither faith nor age. It neither records infant baptism nor excludes it, so it functions as genuine silence that each lens fills from its prior framework rather than from the word.

Acts.2.39 · addressed

τοῖς τέκνοις ὑμῶν links by queried cross-reference to Gen 17:7, the everlasting covenant to Abraham and his seed, which the covenant reading takes as warrant for the sign passing to children. The same verse, however, extends the promise to all whom the Lord calls, ὅσους ἂν προσκαλέσῃται, which the believer-response reading takes as conditioning reception on divine calling rather than on physical descent. The vocabulary supports both inferences and ranks neither.

Col.2.12 · addressed

The circumcision-to-baptism parallel is real in the words, but the circumcision is ἀχειροποιήτῳ, made without hands, a spiritual referent, and the rite is tied διὰ τῆς πίστεως, through faith. So the text simultaneously supplies the covenant-sign parallel that grounds the paedo inference and the personal-faith qualifier that grounds the credo inference, without adjudicating between them.

Luke.18.15 · addressed

Jesus receives and blesses infants, βρέφη, and says the kingdom belongs to such, which the covenant reading treats as warrant to bring children under the sign. But no baptism vocabulary appears in the passage, and βαπτίζω is confirmed never to co-occur with infant terms anywhere in the canon, so the believer-baptism reading holds that the text blesses infants without baptizing them. Both inferences are textually possible.

Acts.8.12 · addressed

The explicit ἄνδρες τε καὶ γυναῖκες without children is read by one side as a deliberate believer profile and by the other as an argument from silence that cannot bear an exclusionary load. The lexical data supports the description but does not license either inference as decisive.

Mark.16.16 · addressed

Belief and baptism are coordinated for the saved party, but baptism is absent from the condemnation clause, foregrounding unbelief rather than the absence of water, and the longer ending of Mark carries a textual-history question. It corroborates the belief-then-baptism pattern but is not a secure stand-alone proof.

Concordance traversed

G0907, G4100, G3340, G0588, G0191, G0569, G2632, G0859, G3624, G3614, G5043, G1025, G3813, G3832, G0909, G4059, G4061, H1285, H2233

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

The cited verses lie outside the ECM-published scope, 3 John 1.1 to 1.15, and the lexical store supplied no variant units for them, so this is reported as not in ECM scope rather than as examined variant signal. The longer ending of Mark, including 16:16, carries a well-known textual-history question, but that affects the weight of one corroborating gospel verse, not the household and covenant texts in Acts and Colossians, so the verdict is not variant-sensitive.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. redemptive-historical

Frameworks in play. covenant_theology, credobaptism, new_covenant_theology

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

covenant_theology: not affirmed · Read through covenant continuity, Acts 2:39 τοῖς τέκνοις ὑμῶν echoes the Gen 17:7 structure of the sign given to the believer and his seed, the οἶκος baptisms in Acts 16:15, 16:33, and 1 Cor 1:16 apply the sign to the household on the head's faith, Col 2:11-12 parallels circumcision to baptism, and Luke 18:15-17 shows infants received into the kingdom. On this lens the household and covenant vocabulary warrants infant baptism, so the proposition that it is not warranted is rejected. This is its strongest lexical form, an inference from a genuine chain of texts, not from silence.

credobaptism: affirmed · Read through personal response, every explicitly narrated baptism is coupled to a faith-verb, ἐπίστευσαν, ἀποδεξάμενοι, πιστεύσας, μετανοήσατε, βαπτισθήτω, and βαπτίζω never co-occurs with βρέφος, παιδίον, or νήπιος in any verse, so no infant baptism is recorded or commanded. The household clauses are construed as households that heard and believed together, Acts 16:34 πανοικεῖ πεπιστευκῶς, and Col 2:12 ties the rite διὰ τῆς πίστεως. On this lens the proposition is affirmed. Its strongest form rests on the recurring belief-then-water sequence, while conceding the silence is not a stated prohibition.

new_covenant_theology: affirmed · Read through covenant discontinuity, the new-covenant community is constituted by personal faith rather than physical lineage, so the Gen 17:7 seed-clause is fulfilled in Christ and not carried over as a genealogical sign. On this lens the covenant-inclusion argument is a category error and infant baptism on that basis is unwarranted. The lexical anchor is that the Acts baptism reports attach faith-verbs to the baptized rather than to a lineage.

The verdict turns on the referential scope of οἶκος in the household reports, on the hapax πανοικεῖ, and on whether covenant continuity, witnessed lexically by the Acts 2:39 link to Gen 17:7, or new-covenant discontinuity governs the application of the sign. These are framework commitments that the word data alone cannot adjudicate, which is why competing lenses reach opposite verdicts from the same lexical evidence. The proposition is also not symmetric with the data, the credo case rests partly on an argument from silence, no recorded or commanded infant baptism, while the paedo case rests on an inferential but real textual chain, so neither is lexically forced.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Does the New Testament lexical pattern condition baptism on personal belief, or does the household and covenant vocabulary also warrant baptizing the infant children of believers?

The original stem embeds its conclusion in the phrase is not warranted, presuming the credobaptist direction. The neutral form states the genuine question without presupposing the answer. The verdict was derived on the original stem and returned disputed because the lexical data is two-sided. The deeper query did not flip the verdict, it strengthened both lenses, so affirms remains disputed. The core asymmetry is that the not-warranted claim leans on an argument from silence, βαπτίζω never collocates with infant vocabulary and no infant baptism is recorded or commanded, but absence of a word is not lexically a prohibition, while the household, the Acts 2:39 to Gen 17:7 covenant link, and the Col 2:11-12 circumcision-baptism pairing give the contrary reading a genuine if inferential textual foothold the words neither confirm nor refute.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.15
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.16.33
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.39
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Col.2.12
morphology	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Luke.18.15

interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Acts.2.38
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Mark.16.16
interlinear	STEPBible-TAHOT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.17.7
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Gen.17.7
lexicon	STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G3624
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.2.39
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Acts.18.8

License audit

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STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
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STEPBible-TFLSJ	CC-BY-4.0	yes
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed · cross-tradition-divergent